

Faculty Facilitation Guide

Running an online cohort

This guide is for the instructor running the cohort. It assumes you know your subject and may be new to teaching it online. The structure of the course does the heavy lifting; your job is presence, judgment, and timely response. Everything here is written to the moment you will actually use it.

BEFORE WEEK ONE

Onboarding checklist

- Read the course at the pace a learner will. Note anything you would say out loud in a classroom; that becomes your first announcement.
- Record a 90 second welcome. Camera on, name the one thing this course will let them do.
- Confirm you can reach the gradebook, the discussion space, and the roster before learners arrive.
- Decide your response window (for example, within one business day) and post it. Then hold to it.

THE WEEKLY RHYTHM

Three touch points, every week

WHEN	MOVE	WHY IT WORKS
Open	Post the week's one question.	Frames the work and gives quiet learners a low-stakes way in.
Midweek	Reply to two threads. Name a pattern you see.	Signals you are present and reading, without answering everything.
Close	Summarize, then preview the next build.	Consolidates learning and reduces the dread of starting cold.

Presence is not volume. Three deliberate touches a week beat a flood of replies that trains learners to wait for you instead of each other.

HIGH-LEVERAGE MOVES

Where small effort pays off

- **Warm the first wrong answer.** The way you respond to the first public mistake sets whether anyone risks a second one. Treat it as useful data.
- **Reply to the thread, not the inbox.** Answering in the open turns one question into a resource for the whole cohort.
- **Name the struggle out loud.** When you see several learners stuck in the same place, say so. It normalizes difficulty and points to the fix.
- **Close the loop on feedback.** When a learner revises after your comment, acknowledge it. That is the moment learning sticks.

COMMON PITFALLS

What to avoid, and what to do instead

Pitfall

Answering every post individually.

Going silent for a week, then over-correcting.

Rewriting the course mid-stream.

Grading only with scores.

Do this instead

Synthesize. One reply that names the pattern serves everyone.

Set a rhythm and keep it small but reliable.

Note the issue, fix it for the next cohort, support this one as built.

Add one sentence of why. The sentence is the teaching.

A NOTE ON PRESENCE

Three kinds, all required

A strong online course balances *social presence* (learners feel seen and safe), *cognitive presence* (the work pushes thinking forward), and *teaching presence* (someone is clearly steering). You supply the first and third directly. The course design supplies scaffolding for the second. When a week feels flat, it is usually one of the three gone missing. Name which, and the fix is obvious.

Abstracted sample. Client names and proprietary content withheld. Structure and method are representative of production work.